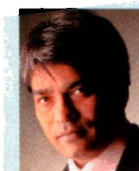


QED SHANKAR AYAR

Bowled Out



Fear the tears of the poor for they can drown the mighty. So said the sages. That the maxim holds true even in the age of T20 was proved last week when the Congress—ergo the UPA—recorded its eleventh retreat in as many hustings. The imagery is unavoidable. Like the Deccan Chargers, the Congress-led UPA is the best team on paper but is yet caught holding the wooden spoon. The analogy is inescapable too. As in T20, governments must use “power play” to launch big ideas while the vanquished are trapped inside the circle. And the opportunity was there: four years of growth, no national calamity nor international contagion and an absentee opposition. Instead, the UPA got lost in a maze of committees and commissions. Today, as it faces the slog overs before the general elections, it finds itself without much on the board and with too few wickets.

The optics suggest that inflation has hurt them but it is more than just the price of cereal and pulse that is hurting. Vast numbers feel left out of the 9-plus per cent growth story. Those with assets—land, house, shares or gold—have prospered while those without or in the quest, find wealth elusive. A square foot of space is selling at Rs 1,20,000 in south Mumbai and just two members of the long list of *Forbes* billionaires added Rs 1,84,000 crore to their wealth in 2007 and 2008. The political impact of this demonstration effect has not been understood on Raisina Hill or Akbar Road. Yes, inequality is a natural by-product of growth but the Government made no attempt beyond setting up an Administrative Reforms Commission to create capillaries that improve life for the majority and make inequality palatable.

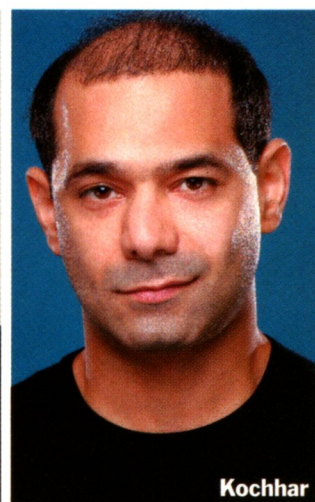
You could argue that this Government, which came on the premise of *aam aadmi ke saath* (with the common man), has initiated two of the biggest spends: the Rs 16,000 crore job guarantee scheme across 594 districts and the Rs 71,000 crore loan waiver for farmers. But the Congress lost earlier polls despite the job guarantee and in Karnataka after the loan waiver because there is a disconnect between real need and the optics of politics. The distinction is between appearing to do something for the poor and actually doing something for the poor. Voters want delivery of services and deliverance from the babu-bribe raj. Not pretty sops, nor lame alibis about coalition politics. They want to see a game-plan, the courage to implement it and a leadership to make the pieces sum up. A la Shane Warne.



SAURABH SINGH



Nair



Kochhar

Theatrical Designs

DELHI The Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI) seems to be caught in a face-off with designers. Anju Modi, Karuna Khaitan, Jatinn Kochhar, Bobby Grover and Niki Mahajan accusing the body's Executive Director Sumeet Nair of misappropriation of funds as well as using the council to promote only a handful of designers. “Sumeet is only interested in his coterie and himself,” says Khaitan, a board member of FDCI. A case has been filed against FDCI and Nair and the matter is sub judice. However, the industry is divided with senior designers like Tarun Tahiliani, Ashish Soni, Rohit Gandhi and Rajesh Pratap Singh supporting Nair.

The drama began during the India Fashion Week in March, when Armand Hadida, owner of the Tranoi trade fair in Paris, came to select designers to participate in the fair. Some designers who were left out allege that Hadida had already been given a list of designers by certain board members. Adding fuel to

fire was a Rs 10 lakh aid extended to designers Anamika Khanna, Manish Arora and Rajesh Pratap Singh for a Paris show and the proposed changes in the memorandum of association of the governing body. Khaitan and Kochhar allege that the FDCI administrative staff, on the instructions of Nair, has been keeping accounts a secret and not submitting the details of his expenses of his trips abroad. Nair says, “Khaitan and some board members, failing to find any irregularities to substantiate their false, bald, and baseless allegations, they are making these general allegations.”

Matters turned worse when Modi's email account was hacked and a mail sent from it to all members apologising for filing the case. Modi has denied this and filed a complaint with the Economic Offences Wing. She says that the FDCI board has been pressuring her to withdraw her complaint. Seems there are more drama in store than were during the Fashion Week itself. **by Nandini Valsh**